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RARE CATCH: The Gujarat arrests have revealed crucial information on the IM, its leadership and agenda

to strengthen the intelligence-gathering set-up. Innovative ideas need to be infused in the system. The response of intelligence agencies is becoming predictable. So while the terrorists keep changing their modus operandi and technology, the intelligence officials have remained boxed in with their old bureaucratised way of thinking. The capability to surprise and also deter the terrorist is missing.

Counter-terrorism expert and executive director of the Institute for Conflict Management, Ajai Sahni, said that there were no short-cuts to proper intelligence gathering. There was a need for capacity-building, proper training and weaponry. "You cannot expect three persons to do a job of 30. There has to be a specialised cadre and force for counter-terrorism. As of now, all agencies are scavenging on IPS officers. One such force, the National Security Guard (NSG), is almost a waste since it is based in Manesar and takes a long time to respond. Also, a large part of the force is also wasted in VIP protection duties," he said. Sahni stressed the need for strengthening

state-level policing and intelligence set-up. "On an average, there are 126 police personnel to 100,000 people. The ratio is worse off in states like Bihar (59 to 1 lakh), Orissa (63 to 1 lakh) and Uttar Pradesh (61 to 1 lakh). In developed countries, the ratio varied from 300 to 500 policemen to 1 lakh people. "If you take into account the quality of education and training of police personnel, the police are just not equipped to prevent terror attacks of this nature. You have a lathi (baton) bearing policemen in the 21st century. You are trying to fight a 21st century threat with a 19th century police force," Sahni added.

Senior security officials point out that bolstering the state intelligence machinery holds the key to checkmating the fast-mutating home-grown terror network. "The local factor is a huge edge for the state intelligence over their Central counterpart," says an official, pointing to how Gujarat, Maharashtra, Madhya Pradesh and Punjab have professionalised their anti-terror wings. The Punjab Police cracked the 2007 Ludhiana cinema blast within four weeks while Gujarat authorities solved the Ahmedabad blasts by relying on a massive database on SIMI's ground network. In Gujarat, a separate wing headed by an IG-rank officer has been keeping track of SIMI alone. To most anti-terror officials, a stringent anti-terror law coupled with strengthening of the state intelligence apparatus holds the key to defeating the growing threat of homegrown terror.

with Ramesh Vinayak

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and a stringent ANTI-TERROR
LAW is the key to tackling the threat.**